

it's the first Windows flavour to support ARM architecture. There's a whole new Start screen with interactive tiles, Ribbon interface introduced in earlier Office suites finally finds its way into Windows Explorer's panel, and aspects of cloud sync are more tightly integrated into Windows 8 than ever before. The central theme to all this major product overhaul is just one thing – familiarity of the platform across devices. And since most of these devices are going to be tablets, smartphones or hybrids with touch input, according to industry experts, it seems Microsoft's arm has finally been forced to make Windows touch-friendly, easily accessible and receptive to finger gestures (about time, eh?), but it hasn't thrown out the (t)rusty old keyboard and mouse just yet.

Predominantly, Windows 8 juggles between Modern UI and the legacy desktop mode – two separate OSes in themselves – while making a case for multitouch input. Wherever Modern and legacy Windows UI meet, irritation and annoyance occurs. And while covering all of them may not be possible here, you will surely encounter it soon enough in your Windows 8 journey – when you try sending an email through Outlook, try sharing an IE link, saving photos, using Windows' local search, and more. It can make you pull your hair out in frustration, and that's just the beginning.

Microsoft gave the world a sneak preview of what was coming in Windows 8 couple of years back with its revamped phone operating system – Windows Phone. It was an important precursor to Windows 8, largely receiving a positive reception in terms of its fresh, bold, tile-based interface. And when Modern UI finally arrived on Windows 8's Developer Preview, people had their reservations (including us here at Digit), questioning Microsoft's wisdom on things like dropping the Start button and forcing people to get accustomed to the whole new UI.

If nothing else, Windows 8 will be remembered for one thing. At a critical juncture in its history, Windows is trying to embrace the future of personal computing without letting go much of its rich (perhaps outdated?) legacy. It's trying to pack in the familiar old feel of Windows 7 with Modern UI and live tiles borrowed from Windows Phone to appease everyone – both the old and the new. Only time will tell whether it's a successful strategy, but it's the only OS

that has this hybrid feel to it right now. And this may well work in its favour.

Touch me, may be

Microsoft's re-imagining of Windows 8 has somewhat paid off simply because the OS' interface tweaks are actually sympathetic to the limitations of touch input – unlike previous Microsoft attempts to ship Windows XP or Windows 7 on a touch-screen device that bombed spectacularly. After having spent enough frustrating time with Windows 8's beta builds on traditional desktops (without touch-screen displays), interacting with Windows' new bells and whistles through a mouse feels more than a bit dysfunctional, not to mention severely out of fashion. It's most discomforting to Windows power users, and we completely understand why.



Touch is still painful on a large screen

However, throw in a multi-touch display enabled device in the mix, and Windows 8 starts making more sense. The very first touch-enabled Windows 8 laptop we reviewed, the Acer Aspire S7, made us realize that touch-enabled small screen devices are the ideal starting points for people transitioning onto Windows 8. Because that's the only form factor (under 13-inch) that makes sense for Windows 8 users to make on-screen gestures directly on the display. Anything else, be it a traditional mouse, notebook's trackpad, or a large touch-enabled display for your traditional desktop, and Windows 8's Modern UI, Charms bar and Edge UI feel cumbersome to use – at least initially. May be that's why Microsoft has retained the good old desktop mode for the traditional users.

However, Julie Larson-Green, head of Windows at Microsoft, recently said that it takes users "six weeks" to start using the new UI features of Windows 8, rather than seek out old, familiar Windows desktop features; whereas 90 per cent users find the

Charms menu in their very first session. Microsoft points to their own telemetry data analyzing how users interact with Windows, but doesn't elaborate on the mix of touchscreen and non-touch devices that make up this statistic.

Do it with apps and cloud

With Windows 8, Microsoft is also introducing the concept of apps (as we all know it from the Mac App Store, iTunes App Store, and Google Play's perspective) downloaded and installed from its very own Windows Store. As an end-user you may not appreciate its significance but at the programming level, Microsoft has implemented something called WinRT. Without getting into too much technical detail, WinRT's a whole new approach towards creating and implementing software programs (or apps) in Windows 8, which isn't just more secure than previous Win32 tools found on Windows 7 but also makes life a whole lot easier for developers to code and deploy newer apps than ever before.

Microsoft packs in a lot of native apps on Windows 8 like Mail, Messaging, People (from Windows Phone), Calendar, Games, etc. Bing isn't just a search app but comes with the power of other apps like News, Sports, Weather, Travel, Finance and, of course, Search. There may be a few minor bugs in some of these apps, but their update mechanism through Windows Store means that they'll be fixed and probably updated with newer features pretty soon.

While most of it is still in the realm of speculation, security will be a big concern for Microsoft's Windows 8, and although on the surface it looks to be more secure than Windows 7, hackers and scammers won't shy away from exploiting bugs on such a significant platform – oh no, sir! How apps will be exploited for this purpose remains to be seen.

Cloud sync is deep-rooted into Windows 8's fibre – right from the first login, where you enter your Live ID, to SkyDrive, even a "Sync" option under "PC Settings" that lets you save your personalization, app, browser, and password settings to the cloud and import them on another Windows 8 terminal. Pretty cool, huh?

Versions and hardware galore

Another first in the history of Windows is the presence of not only user-oriented flavours of Windows 8, but Micro-